
Before you buy

Before you buy a development site

Most sites that disappoint do so because of something that was in the contract all along. Run these checks before you exchange.

- ☐ Read the section 10.7 planning certificate attached to the contract, line by line, and order the fuller 10.7(5) version with the council's extra advice.
 - ☐ Check the zone in the council's LEP (Local Environmental Plan), then the minimum lot size, height limit and floor space ratio (FSR).
 - ☐ Check whether the site sits inside a low and mid-rise housing area: within 800 m walk of a nominated station or town centre.
 - ☐ Look for overlays that can stop or reshape a scheme: heritage, flooding, bushfire, acid sulfate soils, road widening and biodiversity.
 - ☐ Read the title search, and order the section 88B instrument for easements, rights of carriageway and restrictions on use.
 - ☐ Check the sewer service diagram for a main running under the part of the lot you want to build on.
 - ☐ Measure the width at the building line, not just the area: many dual occupancy rules need 12 to 15 metres.
 - ☐ Walk the site: slope and where stormwater drains, trees on and near the boundaries, and poles, street trees or bus stops on the frontage.
 - ☐ Price the extras: council contributions (section 7.11 or 7.12) and the State's Housing and Productivity Contribution.
 - ☐ Work out the realistic yield once setbacks, landscaping and overlays are applied, not the theoretical maximum.
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